The doctor thinks it's dislocated, so he's trying to yank it back into place. It won't budge. He tells me I probably need an operation on it. There is no way of glossing over the fact that the finger is crooked. It looks as if it's been bent in half like a twig. As I leave the office, I walk across the beaches of the Caribbean, the absolute promised land to play cricket in. I am kicking the white sand, shutting out the blues and the yellows and all the positive vibes you get from such beautiful surroundings. I am Charlie Brown, walking the Caribbean with a little black cloud, which I have painstakingly kept and curated from the north of England, following me around. The next day they tell me Stuart Broad is being flown out to replace me. I know the name Stuart Broad – I've come across him once or twice – but I don't know much about him other than he has long blond hair and his dad batted for England. I am packing my stuff as slowly as I can, still thinking of excuses, when the X-rays come back. They show that the finger hasn't been dislocated, but it is broken, and a bit of bone has been dislodged from it too. Yanking it around was probably not the best idea.

In a last effort to dig my heels in and not be replaced, I call Dave Roberts, the Lancashire physio. I ask him whether he can give me some sort of different advice that lets me stay and play. Is there some medical language that will change the doctor's mind? He says, if I really feel like I need to, I could numb it and try to play on. Then, another surgeon who I have chased for a second opinion and has seen the X-ray, says that there is a good chance an operation won't be necessary. I relay this information like a kid who's just found out holiday from school has been doubled. I tell them the news, excitedly, praying for them to change their minds, let me inject this clearly broken finger every day and play in the World Cup. They take a moment, and then agree. I can stay. Stuart Broad is at the airport with his bags packed when he is told he is no longer required.

Stuart is eventually flown out anyway, for another reason, and we both end up batting in the last throes of our final group game against the West Indies. It's futile in terms of a World Cup – it's been another unsuccessful one, but we both hang in there to reach the 301 target to win the game on the last ball. We are unfamiliar with each other, but the joy with which he runs towards me on winning a token game for England makes him instantly a person I want to be around. It's Brian Lara's last game, four years now since I first got him out in a Test. It had been a great catch by Marcus